A CENTRAL AGENCY WAS KEEPING AN EYE ON SHERPURIA'S ACTIVITIES FOR MONTHS AND HAD ALERTED THE UP POLICE TOO

political events helped him expand his network, and he soon established himself as a high-profile "fixer". (A former Union minister, now holding a top constitutional post, is said to have received Rs 25 lakh from Rai to boost his poll campaign ahead of the 2019 Lok Sabha election.)

In 2019, Sherpuria launched YREF in Ghazipur, UP, with the purported aim of funding entrepreneurial initiatives that would generate rural jobs—based on the Modi government's flagship scheme Aatmanirbhar Bharat. Of course, as sources paint it, YREF was just a front for receiving money from his targets, which was then pumped into over 50 "start-ups"—shell companies whose documents glittered with his newly acquired friends as directors.

So what proved to be this master manipulator's undoing? A central agency, says a source, had been keeping an eye on his suspicious activities for months and had alerted the UP Police. This led to the arrest of a close aide, Kashif, from Noida. Following his interrogation, the STF arrested Sherpuria in Kanpur, while he was travelling from Delhi to Ghazipur. And, eventually, en route to a political debut from Ghazipur.

Senior police officials in UP are refraining from going on record, and BJP leaders are keeping a diplomatic silence too, given the high-profile faces cropping up on the Sherpuria storyboard. The Enforcement Directorate, meanwhile, is probing the money-laundering angle, suggest reports. There's more drama left in this story for sure. ■



MOHAMMED ALEEMUDDIN

MUSI PROJECT/ TELANGANA

TO REVIVE A RIVER

By Amarnath K. Menon

What the Cooum is to Chennai or the Sabarmati to Ahmedabad, the Musi is to Telangana capital Hyderabad. Rising in Vikarabad, west of the city, the river travels for about 250 kilometres before it joins the Krishna at Vadapally near Suryapet in Telangana, from where it wends its way across to Andhra Pradesh, and ultimately empties itself into the Bay of Bengal.

Like most rivers in Indian cities, over the years the Musi has also become a destination for 94 per cent of the sewage water from the 54 drains in the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation (GHMC) area—some 800 million gallons a day—and that has reduced the river to nothing more than a 20-feet-wide drain for most of its course through the city. That's not counting the industrial waste, including chemical pollutants from the pharma industry.

Plans to cleanse the river and beautify its environs first came up 17 years ago, in 2006, in united Andhra Pradesh. Successive governments ignored the project till, post-state division, K. Chandrashekar Rao took it up in his first